



Cut short: Shreyas Iyer was named captain for the series, but lasted just 13 balls in the series due to his recurring back issues.

compact in defence when needed, fluid through the off side once set, and unflinching across long innings. Even as the pitch slowed in the second match, Sudharsan remained unruffled, reinforcing his credentials as a player built for the long term.

The defining act, however, belonged to Rahul. His unbeaten 176, his first FC century in India since December 2016, during the second game's mammoth chase of 412, was not about selection pressure but about rhythm and execution. Batting with trademark elegance, he combined patient defence with fluent strokeplay once set, guiding India A to the sixth-highest successful chase on Indian soil. For India's Test opener, it was the perfect tune-up for a busy home season, a reminder of how senior players marry responsibility with flair.

Long-term investment

While the batters dominated, the bowlers had their moments. Left-arm spinner Manav Suthar relied on flight and subtle dip rather than pace, taking eight wickets by luring batters into mistakes. Gurnoor Brar, tall and brisk, generated bounce and seam movement that troubled even

aggressive Australian batters. Though inconsistent at times — especially when banging it in short to natural pull hitters — Brar showed enough to be seen as a talent worth investing in.

Dhruv Jurel wore two hats for India A: captain and middle-order batter. Tasked with leadership for the first time at senior level after Iyer's departure, he didn't look out of place, offering continuous suggestions and managing the field well. As a batter, he displayed versatility — attacking when needed, switching gears, and controlling the flow of play. His proactive knocks — 140 in the first match and 56 in the chase — reinforced the sense that Jurel could thrive as a specialist middle-order batter, not just as a wicketkeeper.

The series was equally vital for N. Jagadeesan after his call-up in England as a backup for the fifth Test. He justified his selection with elegance at the crease, striking well-timed drives and showing technique and temperament against both spin and pace, finishing with 138 runs across three innings. For Abhimanyu Easwaran, however, the series offered little change in fortune. He opened in the first match, scoring a tidy 44, but was once again sidelined in the second to make way for Rahul. Nitish, still easing back from a knee injury, had a quiet series. After missing the first game, he returned in the second but played a restrained role — bowling only nine overs across two innings and contributing 17 runs with the bat.

Valuable experience

For Australia A, the series was equally important — immediate and long-term. With an eye on The Ashes later this year at home, Sam Konstas (pic, left) and Nathan McSweeney showed why they remain contenders for opening slots.

Konstas impressed with an attacking 109 in the first match, followed by a measured 49 in the second, demonstrating his ability to construct innings under pressure. McSweeney was the standout for Australia A, scoring 74 and an unbeaten 85 in the second game, blending composure with timing in

